

Function families

Topics: polynomial, exponential, logarithmic, and trigonometric functions.

Goal: learn the main types of functions, recognise their graphs, and compare how quickly they grow.

Today's question: **What can the shape of a function tell us before we calculate?**

Session	Date
4 of 15	Thu 10 Sep 2026

Where session 4 sits

1 · Course overview and algebra refresher

2 · Sets and set operations

3 · Functions

4 · Function families

5 · Theorem proving

6 · Mathematical induction

7 · Combinatorics and the binomial theorem

8 · Midterm

9 · GCD and divisibility

10 · Modular arithmetic

11 · Vectors

12 · Polynomials

13 · Complex numbers

14 · Course recap and exam preparation

15 · Final exam

TODAY Polynomial, exponential/logarithmic, and trigonometric families.

One input rule, many possible shapes

Yesterday, a function needed a domain, a codomain, and one output for each input. Today, compare these rules on $\mathbb{R}$:

FUNCTION	WHAT HAPPENS WHEN x IS LARGE AND POSITIVE?
x^2	grows like a square
2^x	doubles whenever x increases by 1
$\log_2 x$	grows slowly; only defined for $x > 0$
$\sin x$	repeats forever between -1 and 1

WARM-UP Which function will be larger when x becomes very large: x^2 or 2^x ? Why is checking only $x = 1$ not enough?

By the end of today, you can...

- classify a polynomial by degree, and describe its end behaviour and roots;
- use exponent and logarithm laws only when their conditions are true;
- convert logarithms between bases and solve simple exponential or logarithmic equations;
- compare logarithmic, polynomial, and exponential growth for large inputs;
- transform a graph, and read amplitude, period, and shift from a trigonometric model.

Success means...

explaining **why** you may use a rule, not only using it.

One transformation language works for every family

DEFINITION Start with the graph $y = f(x)$. For

$$g(x) = a f(b(x - h)) + k \quad (b > 0),$$

read from the **inside out**: change x first, then change y .

CHANGE	EFFECT ON THE GRAPH
h	move h units horizontally (right if $h > 0$)
k	move k units vertically (up if $k > 0$)
$ a $	make the graph $ a $ times taller; if $a < 0$, turn it upside down
b	make the graph $1/b$ times as wide

Polynomials

The formula tells us about the graph. Examples: 3 , $-2x + 5$, $x^2 - 4x + 3$, $2x^5 - x$.

In a simplified polynomial, the variable is not in a denominator, under a root, or in an exponent.

Question: Which part of a polynomial tells us what its graph does far left and far right?



Degree is the largest exponent with a coefficient that is not zero

DEFINITION A polynomial has the form

$$p(x) = a_nx^n + \cdots + a_1x + a_0,$$

where $n \geq 0$ and $a_n \neq 0$. Its **degree** is n , and a_n is its **leading coefficient**. For this session, the coefficients a_i are real numbers.

WORKED

POLYNOMIAL	DEGREE	LEADING COEFFICIENT
$-4x^3 + 7x - 1$	3	-4
$5x^2 - 2x^5$	5	-2
6	0	6

METHOD Write the largest power first before you find the degree.

The highest-power term tells us what happens at the ends

DEGREE N	LEADING COEFFICIENT A_N	LEFT END	RIGHT END
even	positive	up	up
even	negative	down	down
odd	positive	down	up
odd	negative	up	down

READING IT When x is very large positive or very large negative, $p(x)$ behaves like $a_n x^n$. Here **up** means the value becomes very large positive; **down** means it becomes very large negative.

EXAMPLE $p(x) = -2x^5 + 7x^2 - 1$ has odd degree and a negative leading coefficient, so it goes **up on the left** and **down on the right**.

Roots are where the graph meets the x -axis

DEFINITION

A number r is a **root** (or zero) of p when $p(r) = 0$.

FACTOR THEOREM

$$p(r) = 0 \iff (x - r) \text{ is a factor of } p(x).$$

EXAMPLE

$p(x) = x^3 - 4x = x(x^2 - 4) = x(x - 2)(x + 2)$,
so the roots are -2 , 0 , and 2 .

AT MOST

A nonzero polynomial of degree n has **at most** n different real roots.

Read a quadratic from its formula

ACTIVITY 1 GROUPS OF THREE

12 MIN

For $q(x) = -(x - 2)^2 + 3$:

1. State the degree and leading coefficient.
2. Describe the transformation from $y = x^2$.
3. State the vertex and end behaviour.
4. Find the roots in exact form (do not use decimals).

Share: one group explains why the two roots are $2 \pm \sqrt{3}$, rather than $\pm\sqrt{3}$.

Work outwards from the completed square

METHOD

1. Expand mentally to get the degree; the number in front of the square is the leading coefficient.
2. Match q against $a f(b(x - h)) + k$ with $f(x) = x^2$: read h , then k , then a .
3. The vertex sits where the square is zero, so solve $x - h = 0$.
4. For roots, isolate the square and take **both** square roots.

ANSWER Degree 2, leading coefficient -1 ; shift right 2, up 3, then reflect vertically; vertex $(2, 3)$; both ends down.

$$-(x - 2)^2 + 3 = 0 \iff (x - 2)^2 = 3$$

so $x - 2 = \pm\sqrt{3}$ and $x = 2 \pm \sqrt{3}$.

THE TRAP Answering $\pm\sqrt{3}$ drops the horizontal shift. Undo the square first, then undo the shift.

Exponentials and logarithms

Repeated multiplication and its inverse. If adding 1 to the input always multiplies the output by the same number, the pattern is exponential.

$$2^0 = 1, \quad 2^1 = 2, \quad 2^2 = 4, \quad 2^3 = 8$$

A logarithm answers the reverse question: $2^x = 8$ asks: "What exponent gives 8?"



An exponential function has the variable in the exponent

DEFINITION

$$f(x) = b^x, \quad b > 0, b \neq 1$$

Every exponential graph passes through $(0, 1)$ because $b^0 = 1$. The line $y = 0$ is a horizontal **asymptote**: the graph approaches it but never reaches it.

BASE	BEHAVIOUR	DOMAIN AND RANGE
$b > 1$	growth	domain $\mathbb{R}$, range $(0, \infty)$
$0 < b < 1$	decay	domain $\mathbb{R}$, range $(0, \infty)$

An exponential model uses the same multiplier at every step

MODEL

$$N(t) = N_0 r^t,$$

where $N_0 > 0$ is the starting amount and $r > 0$ is the multiplier per time unit.

MULTIPLIER R	INTERPRETATION
$r = 1.20$	increase by 20% per time unit
$r = 0.85$	decrease by 15% per time unit

EXAMPLE $N(t) = 100(1.2)^t$ gives $N(3) = 172.8$. The time unit must be named: hours, days, years, or something else.

Make the bases match, then set the exponents equal

RULE For $b > 0$ and $b \neq 1$,

$$b^u = b^v \implies u = v.$$

WORKED EXAMPLE

$$3^{2x-1} = 27$$

$$3^{2x-1} = 3^3$$

$$2x - 1 = 3$$

$$x = 2$$

Each line has the same solution as the line before it.

A logarithm is an exponent

DEFINITION For $b > 0$, $b \neq 1$, and $x > 0$,

$$\log_b x = y \iff b^y = x.$$

EXAMPLES

$$\log_2 8 = 3, \quad \log_{10}(0.01) = -2, \quad \ln(e^5) = 5.$$

DOMAIN $y = \log_b x$ has domain $(0, \infty)$ and range $\mathbb{R}$. There is no real value for $\log_b 0$ or $\log_b(-4)$.

Log laws change multiplication into addition

LAWS For $u > 0$ and $v > 0$:

$$\log_b(uv) = \log_b u + \log_b v$$

$$\log_b\left(\frac{u}{v}\right) = \log_b u - \log_b v$$

$$\log_b(u^c) = c \log_b u$$

THIS IS USUALLY FALSE

$$\log_b(u + v) \neq \log_b u + \log_b v \quad \text{in general.}$$

Counterexample: with $u = v = 1$, the two sides are $\log_2(1 + 1) = 1$ and $\log_2 1 + \log_2 1 = 0$.

First find the values of x that are allowed

ACTIVITY 2 PAIRS

14 MIN

Solve over the real numbers: $\log_2(x - 1) + \log_2(x + 1) = 3$.

1. Find the values of x allowed by both logarithms.
2. Combine the logarithms using a log law.
3. Solve the resulting equation.
4. Check every possible solution in the original equation.

Share: explain why $x = -3$ is rejected even though it solves the squared equation.

Domain first, then algebra, then check

METHOD

1. Write the domain before touching the equation: every $\log_2$ input must be positive.
2. Combine the two logarithms with the product law, which needs both inputs positive.
3. Undo the logarithm using $\log_2 A = 3 \iff A = 2^3$.
4. Test every candidate against step 1, then substitute into the original equation.

ANSWER $x - 1 > 0$ and $x + 1 > 0$ give $x > 1$. Then

$\log_2((x - 1)(x + 1)) = 3$, so $x^2 - 1 = 8$, $x^2 = 9$, $x = \pm 3$.
Only $x = 3$ lies in the domain. Check: $\log_2 2 + \log_2 4 = 1 + 2 = 3$.

THE TRAP $x = -3$ solves $x^2 = 9$ but not the original equation – squaring is where extra solutions appear.

Change a log base; compare growth only for large n

BASE CHANGE When $x > 0$, $a > 0$, $b > 0$, and neither base is 1:

$$\log_b x = \frac{\log_a x}{\log_a b}.$$

So changing the log base only multiplies the answer by a constant.

GROWTH For fixed $d > 1$, $k > 0$, and $c > 1$, when the positive integer n becomes large,

$$\log_d n < n^k < c^n$$

This is called an **eventual** comparison: the inequality is true once n is large enough, but it may not be true for every $n \geq 1$.

Rank the functions when n is large

ACTIVITY 3 GROUPS OF THREE

12 MIN

Put these in order from slowest growth to fastest growth when n is large: $\log_2 n$, n , $n \log_2 n$, n^2 , 2^n .

1. Why is $n \log_2 n$ larger than n once n is large?
2. Why does one numerical example not prove the full ranking?
3. Which expression is most likely to grow too quickly in an algorithm?

Share: one group gives the complete ranking and says why "when n is large" matters.

Compare neighbours, not all five at once

METHOD

1. Commit to a candidate order first; then you only have four adjacent pairs to justify.
2. For each pair, divide one by the other and ask what happens as n grows.
3. Name the n from which your claim holds — that is what "eventually" means.

ANSWER

$$\log_2 n < n < n \log_2 n < n^2 < 2^n$$

For $n > 2$, $\log_2 n > 1$, so $n \log_2 n > n$. And $n \log_2 n < n^2$ because $\log_2 n < n$. The exponential is the dangerous one for large inputs.

THE TRAP At $n = 2$, $n^2 = 4 = 2^n$. One value can tie or even reverse the order, so it proves nothing.

Trigonometric functions

Graphs that repeat. From the unit circle, $-1 \leq \sin x \leq 1$ and $-1 \leq \cos x \leq 1$ for $x \in \mathbb{R}$;

and, in radians, $\sin(x + 2\pi) = \sin x$ and $\cos(x + 2\pi) = \cos x$.

Repeating graphs can model cycles: daylight, tides, sound, rotation, and seasonal demand.



Read a sine model from its parameters

DEFINITION

$$y = A \sin(B(x - C)) + D, \quad A \neq 0, B > 0$$

If $A < 0$, the wave is turned upside down before it is moved by D .

THE PARAMETERS

FEATURE	VALUE
midline	$y = D$
amplitude (distance from the midline to a peak)	$ A $
period	$\frac{2\pi}{B}$
horizontal shift	move C units horizontally (right if $C > 0$)
range	$[D - A , D + A]$

Worked model: daily temperature

MODEL Let t be hours after midnight. Consider

$$T(t) = 4 \sin\left(\frac{\pi}{12}(t - 3)\right) + 28.$$

The maximum occurs at $t = 9$ hours; the minimum occurs at $t = 21$ hours.

FEATURE	INTERPRETATION
amplitude 4	temperature varies 4° from its average
midline 28	average temperature is 28°
period 24	one complete cycle takes 24 hours
range [24, 32]	lowest and highest temperatures predicted by the model

Interpret before calculating

ACTIVITY 4 PAIRS

12 MIN

For $H(t) = 1.5 \cos\left(\frac{\pi}{6}(t - 2)\right) + 4$:

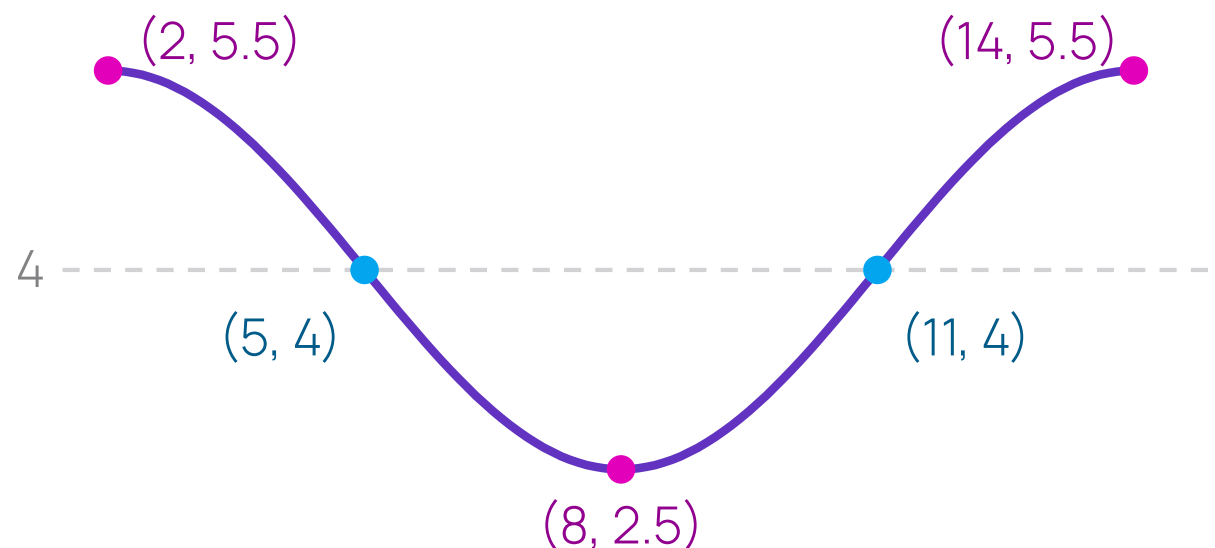
1. Find the amplitude, midline, period, and range.
2. When does the first maximum after $t = 0$ occur?
3. Sketch one cycle. Label a maximum, a minimum, and two points where the graph crosses its midline.

Share: explain why the period is 12, not $\pi/6$.

Read the parameters, then walk one cycle in quarter steps

METHOD

1. Match $A \cos(B(t - C)) + D$: here $A = 1.5$, $B = \frac{\pi}{6}$, $C = 2$, $D = 4$.
2. Amplitude $|A| = 1.5$, midline $y = 4$, period $\frac{2\pi}{B} = 12$, range $[2.5, 5.5]$.
3. Cosine peaks when its input is 0, so $t - 2 = 0$ gives $t = 2$, then every 12.
4. Step a quarter period (3) at a time to land the crossings and the minimum.



THE TRAP The period is 12, not $\frac{\pi}{6}$: B sits *inside* the cosine, so divide 2π by it.

Work independently

1 For $p(x) = x^3 - 4x$, describe what happens on the far left and far right, and find all real roots.

2 Solve $5^{2x} = 125$.

3 For $y = 3 \cos\left(\frac{\pi}{4}(t + 2)\right) - 1$, state the amplitude, period, horizontal shift, and range.

RULE Write one sentence of justification for each answer. A correct number without its reason is incomplete.

What today was about

- The **leading term** tells us what a polynomial graph does at the ends; roots are where it meets the x -axis.
- An exponential has a **constant multiplier**. A logarithm records the exponent, and its input must be positive.
- For large inputs: **logarithmic** < **polynomial** < **exponential** growth.
- A trigonometric model describes repetition through **amplitude**, **period**, **shift**, and **midline**.

Problem Set 4

Growth comparisons, legal logarithm manipulation, and one periodic-model interpretation with written justification.

Next session: **theorem proving** — direct proof, contrapositive, contradiction, and counterexample.